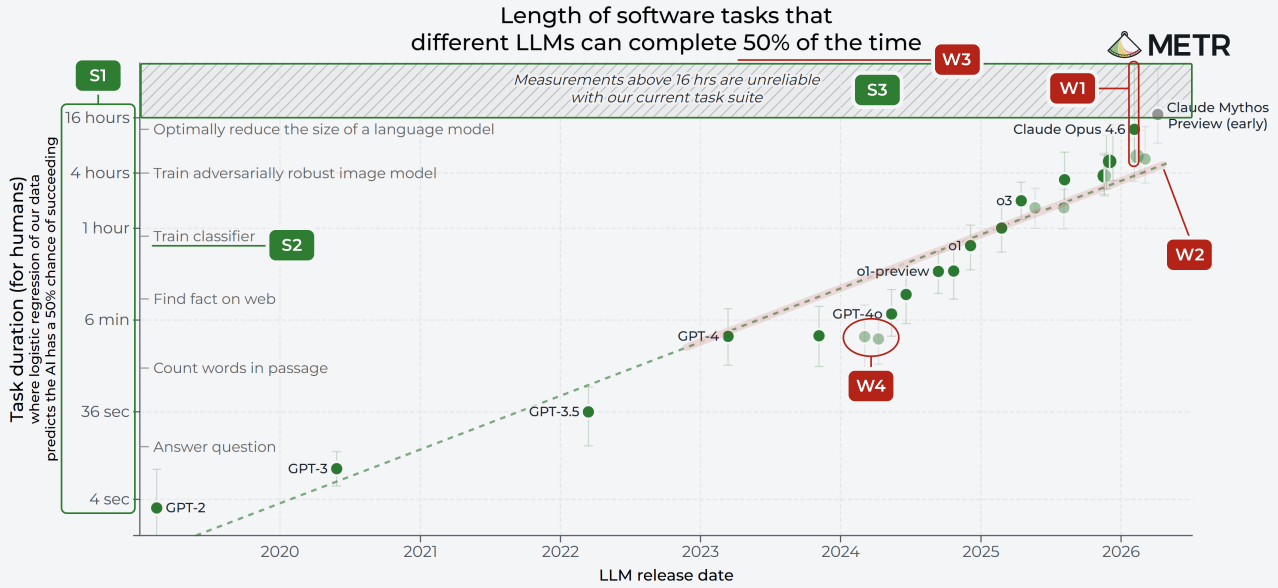
METR's Time Horizon Chart Is Easy to Read, and Easy to Overread

Valmik Nahata Varun Sinha Rishab Kolan Rishil Chintalapati
UC San Diego, DSC 106 Project 2.5 · {vnahata, v1sinha, rkolan, rchintalapati}@ucsd.edu

Original chart | Dataset | METR analysis code



METR, Time Horizon 1.1, 50% success, log scale. Our additions: S strength W weakness

Strengths

S1 Log scale makes doubling linear
Steady doubling becomes a steady slope, read by position on a common scale, the most accurate channel (L4). Equal ratios get equal distances, as Weber's law suggests (L4).

S2 Example tasks give the axis meaning
"Train classifier" near 1 hour maps the physical unit, minutes, onto a conceptual one, kinds of work (data models, L2).

S3 It marks where its data stops
Hatching and the gray Mythos dot pop out preattentively (L4), so the chart claims nothing its tasks cannot measure (expressiveness, L2).

Weaknesses

W1 Uncertainty is drawn at 20% opacity
Opus 4.6 reads as 12 h; its 95% CI spans 5 to 61 h. Faint whiskers sink into the ground (figure and ground, L5). **Fix:** wide CI bars.

W2 One straight line hides a bend
Every model since o3 sits above it. Like Anscombe's quartet (L1), one summary hides structure; continuity (L5) reads one pace. **Fix:** a recent fit.

W3 "50%" carries the headline
At 80%, Opus 4.6 falls from 12 h to 70 min, yet the threshold sits in a rotated label that needs attentive reading (L4). **Fix:** plot both.

W4 Luminance used for a category
Frontier or not is nominal, but light green is an ordered channel with no key (expressiveness, L2). Six models are half dots. **Fix:** hue, key, jitter.

Marks

Point	one AI model (26 in all)
Vertical line	95% bootstrap CI
Dashed line	METR's exponential fit
Hatched area	above 16 h
Aa Text	model and task names

Channels

x position	release date	Q interval
y position, log	50% horizon (human min)	Q ratio
Whisker length	width of the CI	Q ratio
Luminance	frontier at release or not	N
Gray hue, texture	beyond the 16 h ceiling	N

Our reanalysis

Since o3, every frontier model sits **above** METR's line. A fit from 2024 on doubles every **105 days** (METR: 188).

